

Combined Action Program

With the Viet Cong taking refuge in remote villages of South Vietnam, the US Marine Corps turned to a new counterinsurgency method. The Combined Action Program sent Marines into towns and hamlets to forge positive relationships with the locals.

◀◀ BEFORE

Before America's role in the war escalated, US Special Forces made efforts to endear themselves to local civilian populations.

PRECEDENTS FOR CAP

The **Green Berets** had trained the Montagnards in counterinsurgency, but it was the Army's **Strategic Hamlet Program** that was the precursor of the Combined Action Program. Under the program, the Army **relocated** villagers to specially fortified hamlets and declared their former homes to be free-fire zones for rooting out insurgents in search-and-destroy operations.



GREEN BERET WITH VILLAGE CHILDREN

Despite General William Westmoreland's use of the attrition strategy and search-and-destroy tactics, the war remained a political struggle in need of political solutions. American units throughout South Vietnam embraced civic action as a means of winning hearts and minds, but the Marines built an entire program around it.

The US Army's primary strategy was one of attrition. It sought to prove to the North Vietnamese and Viet Cong that they could not win the war and should therefore seek a settlement. This strategy ensured a great deal of destruction, but it did little to stop NVA or Viet Cong fighters from receiving sanctuary at the village level. When the Army did engage in civic action to improve civil-military relations, it did so in addition to—not in lieu of—search-and-destroy operations. This shooting war was at odds with the Army's efforts to win hearts and minds.

Marine methods